

System Project: Teamwork Requirements (2026 SM2)

Why are the teamwork requirements designed this way?

A large majority of the details on this page are based on student reflections about teamwork, which were expressed at the conclusion of the multiple project-based subject that the teaching team members have taught in the past. Hence, the teaching team honestly intends that everything on this page improves your team's project process, progress, and outcomes.

Raison d'être:

The ELEN90095 subject's "raison d'être" is for everyone to have a great System Project learning experience in an interdisciplinary team. So please talk to the teaching team about any aspects of teamwork and project work (be they positive, negative, or neutral aspects).

Specifically for Teamwork Requirements, if any part of this page feels like useless box-ticking, then discuss with the teaching team immediately so that we make changes already this semester!

Contents for the remainder of this page

We have purposely made this a rather long Canvas page so that everything teamwork related is in one place. The compromise is that it can be annoying to scroll and particularly annoying when viewing on a mobile phone. The intention is that:

- **Every individual** reads this page once to understand the expectations of the teaching team.
- **Your team** collaboratively uses the "Teamwork Document" template to both: facilitate productive teamwork; and collate the evidence required for teamwork assessment (details and template below).

The remaining contents of this page are:

"Teamwork Document" template	This section provides the template that you MUST use and regularly SUBMIT to receive the teamwork marks for the
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	System Project.
Mandatory teamwork protocols	This section provides the way that you MUST conduct your teamwork using the "Teamwork Document" so as to receive the teamwork marks for the System Project.
Peer feedback activities	This section provides details about how formal peer feedback will be conducted (using "Feedback Fruits").
Critical engineering decision-making	The section provides some suggested methods to use when you team is making a critical decision that significantly influences what everyone is working on.
Interpersonal challenges	This section provides concrete methods for you to use when challenging situations arise with interpersonal dynamics.
Leadership and service	This sections provides a few paragraphs of mandatory reading to help every individual have an opportunity to build their leadership (and service) experience.

"Teamwork Document" templates

The templates and instructions are provided in the respective teamwork assignment.

Mandatory teamwork protocols

- You and your team **MUST** conduct your teamwork in accordance with the protocols in this section.
- If your team wishes to deviate from any one of the protocols, then your team **MUST** obtain permission by sending the [Teaching Team \(https://canvas.lms.unimelb.edu.au/courses/238681/pages/teaching-team-details-2026-sm2\)](https://canvas.lms.unimelb.edu.au/courses/238681/pages/teaching-team-details-2026-sm2) an email with:
 - A description of your intended change; and
 - A short justification for why you wish to make this change.
- This is **authentically** what it is like to work at a company:
 - There are mandatory processes for how to go about team management; and
 - There are approval requirements for deviating from mandatory process.

The teamwork protocols that you **MUST** follow are:

- **Microsoft Teams:** Create and use a "Team" in MS Teams, which is to be used for messaging and some shared documents.
 - This should be a "Team" and not just a group chat within MS Teams.
 - Ensure that every team member turns on all notifications for all channels within the team.
 - You are encouraged add a "misc" channel as a low stakes location for project-related ad hoc thoughts, ideas, photos, code, theory, links, etc.
 - We are forcing the use of MS Teams because it is UniMelb's platform of choice, and it reflects **authentic workplace practices** where you are required to use the companies chosen software and behave respectfully and professionally in your use of that software.
- **Task Board:** Create and use a Task Board for tracking and allocating tasks.
 - **MS Teams has an integrated add-on that allows you to add a Task Board directly to your MS Teams:**
 - Click the "+" in the top bar of a channel.
 - Select "Planner".
 - Select "Save" to continue.
 - Click "Create a new plan".
 - Select "Basic".
 - Give you plan a name and click "Save".
 - In the top bar, ensure the "Board" view is selected.
 - Click "Add a new bucket" to add columns titled **"To Do"**, **"In progress"**, **"Complete"** (and any other columns your want).
 - Now you board is setup and you can add tasks under the columns.
 - Full details on the official "[Getting started with Planner in Teams](https://support.microsoft.com/en-au/office/getting-started-with-planner-in-teams-7a5e58f1-2cee-41b0-a41d-55d512c4a59c)  (<https://support.microsoft.com/en-au/office/getting-started-with-planner-in-teams-7a5e58f1-2cee-41b0-a41d-55d512c4a59c>)" website.
 - There are many templates and methods for using a Task Board:
 - One of the simplest is a Kanban Board with only 3 columns for: **"To Do"**, **"In progress"**, **"Complete"**.
 - Read this "What is a Kanban Board" article from Atlassian (or watch the video there) to find out more, especially the part about limiting the amount of work in progress as a key method for making faster progress.
 - This is a [Kanban Template provided by Trello](https://trello.com/templates/engineering/kanban-template-LGHXvZNL)  (<https://trello.com/templates/engineering/kanban-template-LGHXvZNL>).
- **Team Charter:**
 - Submit a getting started charter via this assignment: [System Project Teamwork: Getting Started Team Charter](https://canvas.lms.unimelb.edu.au/courses/238681/assignments/683419) (<https://canvas.lms.unimelb.edu.au/courses/238681/assignments/683419>)
- **Weekly Summaries:** Regularly submit a summary of each individuals contributions by following the template provided in the respective assignments.
- **Critical engineering decision-making:** identify and try out a formal method to help you make any such decisions.

- **Interpersonal challenges:** identify and action any such challenges early (see flow charts in the "Interpersonal Challenges" section below).

Peer feedback activities

- Based on the experience and suggestions of students from the 2025 cohort, we are still deciding how best to run peer feedback this year.

Critical engineering decision-making

There are many different techniques and activities that have been tried and tested to handle engineering decision-making challenges! Rather than give a long list, we encourage you to do a internet search for a technique that **matches the specifics** of the decision your team is battling with (and likely GenAI gives reasonable suggestions for techniques to consider).

To exemplify, two possible techniques are:

- **The "6 thinking hats" technique** [\(https://www.debonogroup.com/services/core-programs/six-thinking-hats/\)](https://www.debonogroup.com/services/core-programs/six-thinking-hats/), which guides the team to collaboratively and objectively construct an analysis of the situation that aids in making the final team decision.
- Approach the teaching team in a way that invites their unbiased opinion on the decision your team is battling with.

Interpersonal challenges

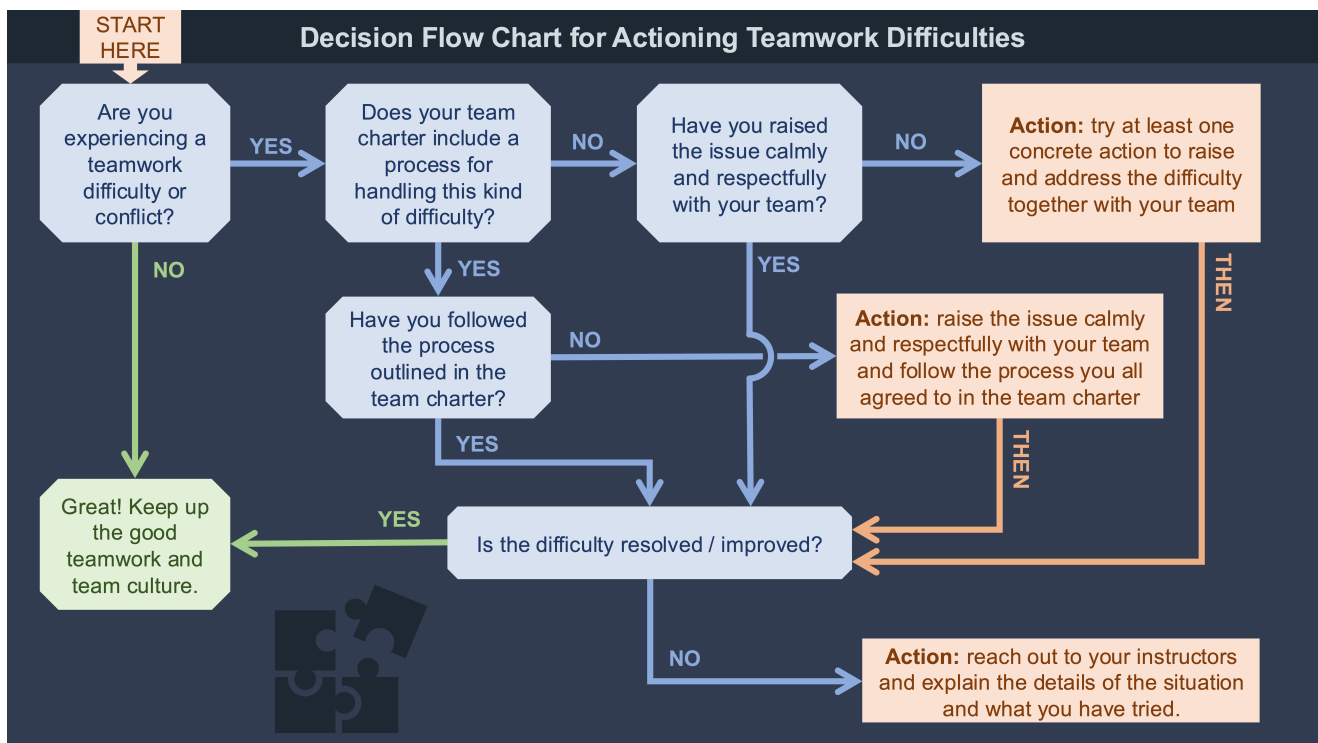
- We recognise that teamwork **can be challenging** — and that those challenges **can be overcome**.
- **We are here** to support you.
- **Help us to help you** by using the flowchart below to contact the teaching team **as early as possible** and necessary!

When should you contact your instructors?

Anytime your team dynamic or culture feels **"off"**, use the flowchart (starting at the top-left) to work out where you are at and what to do next.

[AI4R_2025_SM2_Teamwork_Difficulty_Flowchart.pdf](https://canvas.lms.unimelb.edu.au/courses/238681/files/27131236?wrap=1)

[\(https://canvas.lms.unimelb.edu.au/courses/238681/files/27131236?wrap=1\)](https://canvas.lms.unimelb.edu.au/courses/238681/files/27131236?wrap=1)



How to raise an issue with your team

As per the flowchart, it can be helpful (and often empowering!) to raise the issue with your team directly — **if you feel safe and comfortable doing so (if you do not feel or comfortable, then contact the teaching team about your issue).**

Some tips for raising concerns constructively:

- **Use “I” language:** Focus on how *you* are experiencing the situation. For example,
 - Try: *"I'm finding it hard to keep momentum when we don't all meet regularly."*
 - Avoid: *"You never show up to meetings."*
- **Be specific and objective:** Describe what's happening, not just how it feels.
 - E.g.: *"We agreed to submit the draft by Friday, but it wasn't uploaded until Sunday."*
- **Invite collaboration:** Try to frame it as a shared issue to work on together.
 - E.g.: *"How can we make sure we're all on the same page for deadlines moving forward?"*
- **Keep it kind and respectful:** Assume positive intent where possible, and aim to find solutions rather than assign blame.

If you try this and things still aren't improving — or if you would prefer support before having the conversation — that's totally fine. That's where we come in.

How to contact your instructors

Simply send us an email ([Teaching Team Details \(2026 SM2\)](mailto:Teaching Team Details (2026 SM2))).

(<https://canvas.lms.unimelb.edu.au/courses/238681/pages/teaching-team-details-2026-sm2>.)

that includes:

- A clear explanation of the teamwork challenges you are facing.
- What you've already tried to address the issue.
 - If it's a sensitive issue, you may not have raised it with your team. **That's okay**, just let us know that, too.

Some additional links for advice on teamwork difficulties

- Harvard Business Review (HBR) article on "[4 Common Types of Team Conflict — and How to Resolve Them](https://hbr.org/2024/05/4-common-types-of-team-conflict-and-how-to-resolve-them)" [↗\(https://hbr.org/2024/05/4-common-types-of-team-conflict-and-how-to-resolve-them\)](https://hbr.org/2024/05/4-common-types-of-team-conflict-and-how-to-resolve-them)."
- Harvard Division of Continuing Education article on "[Preventing and Managing Team Conflict](https://professional.dce.harvard.edu/blog/preventing-and-managing-team-conflict/#Why-Do-Workplace-Conflicts-Happen--)" [↗\(https://professional.dce.harvard.edu/blog/preventing-and-managing-team-conflict/#Why-Do-Workplace-Conflicts-Happen--\)](https://professional.dce.harvard.edu/blog/preventing-and-managing-team-conflict/#Why-Do-Workplace-Conflicts-Happen--)."
- UniMelb Academic Skills resource on "[Working in Groups](https://students.unimelb.edu.au/academic-skills/resources/communicating-in-class/communicating-with-peers/working-in-groups)" [↗\(https://students.unimelb.edu.au/academic-skills/resources/communicating-in-class/communicating-with-peers/working-in-groups\)](https://students.unimelb.edu.au/academic-skills/resources/communicating-in-class/communicating-with-peers/working-in-groups)."
- University of Queensland Student Support resource on "[Resolving Group Work Issues](https://my.uq.edu.au/information-and-services/student-support/study-skills/group-work/resolving-group-work-issues)" [↗\(https://my.uq.edu.au/information-and-services/student-support/study-skills/group-work/resolving-group-work-issues\)](https://my.uq.edu.au/information-and-services/student-support/study-skills/group-work/resolving-group-work-issues)."

Leadership and service:

We can't teach you teamwork, but we can facilitate the teamwork experience:

We have experienced that explicit teaching of teamwork theory and strategies as a "lectorial" is not very impactful (despite our best effort to make such sessions interactive).

Instead, we aim to facilitate a project where: **(1)** teamwork is worthwhile to engage with for achieving a more exciting project output; and **(2)** there is some form of assessment-like insight into your ongoing teamwork.

Help us by reading what follows and taking the actions that we encourage.

Take on service and experiment with leadership:

Leadership and service, and how they are intertwined, is a complex topic and you are encourage to search for and read about various perspectives on this topic. The following is intended to give you a starting point for how to approach teamwork in this subject.

Word	Definition	Example
Service	Tasks and actions that needs to be done for managing the	Note taker for team meetings.

	team and could be done by anyone. Often service roles: • Have specific names; and • With that name comes with a bunch of tasks that person needs to completed behalf of the whole team; which in turn • Give that person influence over others by having the authority to "tell" them what to do. • An individual serving is such a role should be shown appreciation and thanks for their service.and these roles give authority to that person,	
Leadership.	Influencing other to do certain things without have any formal authority over them for that topic.	A team-member who uses a positive demeanor to get every other team-member to fill in the meeting notes document in advance of the team meetings, resulting in much more productive discussion during the actual team meeting.

A **common misconception** is that that holding a position of **service** automatically means that you are showing leadership. The reality is that **leadership** is determined by how you conduct yourself as part of fulfilling the responsibilities required from you by that position of service.

We strongly encourage every individual to:

- **Take on a service role within their team.**
- **Experiment with showing leadership (i.e., influence without coercion) as part of the way that you carry out your service role.**